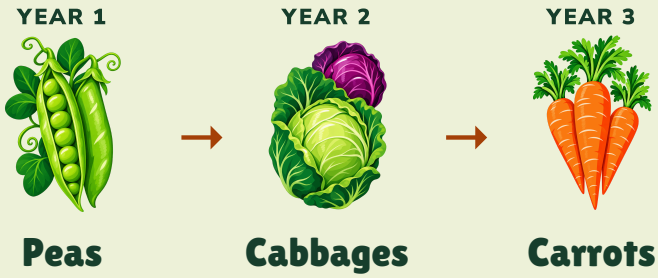
Crop rotation & planning

Rotation means moving plant families to different ground instead of growing the same or similar crops in one place year after year. It has two useful jobs: reducing shared pests and diseases, and helping leafy crops use nitrogen left by peas and beans.

One bed, three different families

Peas, cabbages and carrots belong to different families. Changing families helps break pest cycles; peas can also leave nitrogen for the cabbages.



Keep a simple record

Sketch your beds and write down what grew where, including a second crop in the same year. Next season, move the main crop to ground that held an unrelated family. Changing cabbage for broccoli does not count: they share too many problems.

Let plants help each other

Bacteria in pea and bean root nodules fix nitrogen from the air. Leave healthy roots to decay for following leafy greens; add mature compost where needed. Manure or compost suits heavy eaters like potatoes and cucumbers; follow these with light feeders such as carrots.

Crop families: useful examples

Brassicas	Cabbage, kale, broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cauliflower, kohlrabi, radish, swede and turnip
Alliums	Onion, shallot, leek and garlic
Legumes	Peas and beans
Potato family	Potatoes, tomatoes, aubergines, peppers and chillies
Carrot family	Carrot, parsnip, celery, celeriac, Florence fennel, coriander and dill
Beet family	Beetroot, spinach and leaf beet (chard)
Cucumber family	Cucumber, courgette, marrow, pumpkin and squash
Lettuce family	Lettuce, chicory and endive

A rotation is not a disease cure

Clubroot and onion white rot, to take the two worst examples, can remain in soil for many years. A short circuit round the beds does not make infected ground clean. Keep contaminated soil off clean beds, and do not put infected allium debris into good compost.

John: Raised Beds and rotation notes; crop and Troubles JSON. Families: Garden Organic, Saskatchewan. Nitrogen: UConn, AHDB.

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One bed, two complementary crops in the same year



Broad beans
Legumes

→



Kale
Brassicas

After early broad beans, use the bed for kale. Sow kale separately in June or early July; plant promptly when ready, often July or early August. Leave the bean roots in the soil by cutting the plants off at the base. As the roots decay, some of the nitrogen fixed while the beans grew becomes available to help feed the kale. See Kale, pages 40–41.

Four beds, four years

The acme of rotation is the traditional four-block rotation system, as seen in many an old gardening manual. It's prescriptive, but it gives you a clear plan for the whole plot. Divide the growing area into four beds or groups of beds, then move each crop group on one place each year.

Year	Bed A	Bed B	Bed C	Bed D
1	Peas & beans	Brassicas	Potatoes	Onions & roots
2	Brassicas	Potatoes	Onions & roots	Peas & beans
3	Potatoes	Onions & roots	Peas & beans	Brassicas
4	Onions & roots	Peas & beans	Brassicas	Potatoes

Brassicas follow peas and beans to use nitrogen released from their decaying roots. Read across for one year, down for one bed. Year 5 repeats Year 1.

Put each crop in its group

Crop rotation groups are not always obvious. In the four-block system, radishes, swedes and turnips belong with the brassicas. Onions and other roots share a block even though they include different families.

Plan the changeover

Keep recording every crop, including a second crop in the same year. A bed may still be occupied when the new year starts. Make the changeover after harvesting, in time for the next crop's sowing or planting window.

Alternative strategy: A right British muddle

If you only have a small plot, or you have many different-sized beds, you can just mix plants up in small groups and let randomness and Nature do the rotation for you. It will still work; just keep things moving, and every year, do something different in each bed.

John: rotation notes and June allotment video; crop JSON. Rotation: RHS. Nitrogen: UConn, AHDB, Garden Organic.